Joint Committee on Artificial Intelligence

20 January 2026

The Use of AI in the Public Sector

Opening Statement

Good morning Chair, Deputies and Senators. We welcome the opportunity to meet today and to brief the committee as part of your examination of the use of Artificial Intelligence in the Public Sector.

If I might, I would like to begin with a few brief words about the Department of Foreign Affairs and Trade, a global organisation with offices in Ireland and in over 100 locations around the world.

The Department works to protect and promote peace on our island; support our diaspora communities; ensure active and principled membership of the UN, the EU and other international fora; deliver a high-quality international development programme; and expand Ireland's presence and influence abroad so as to underpin prosperity and security at home.

The Department also provides a first class service to Irish citizens. The Passport Service, a key service delivered by the Department, provides passports to some one million Irish citizens at home and overseas each year. The Service is at the forefront of the government's programme for the delivery of on-line services to citizens.

As the Committee is aware, the rapid acceleration of AI, and in particular advancements in generative AI, opens new opportunities but also brings unprecedented challenges. Ireland's National AI Strategy – *AI: Here for Good* – takes a human-centric approach to governance, emphasising fairness, transparency, and the building of public trust in AI. These principles are at the core of our Department's approach to AI, both domestically and in our global engagement.

The Department's Statement of Strategy 2025 – 2028 outlines our ambition to build our capacity to innovate, as a Department that consistently delivers excellent public service, and is agile and responsive to national and global developments.

Part of delivering on this ambition to build our capacity in emerging technologies, and in particular AI, can be seen in the competition currently underway to recruit, at Assistant Secretary-level, a Chief Information Officer for the Department. This will be a new role on our Management Board, responsible for leading digital transformation across the Department, including the Passport Service and our global network of diplomatic missions.

AI offers many new possibilities for public service transformation. As with all Government Departments, we are working to avail of the possibilities whilst mitigating the risks. The Department is already active in exploring the potential of AI to enhance our work.

In 2023, the Department developed an interim policy on Generative AI for all staff of the Department. This policy, designed from a cyber-security perspective, outlines that public versions of Generative AI services must not be used for business purposes. This was to mitigate the risk of official or sensitive data being submitted to external sources beyond the Department's control.

As the Committee is aware, the *Guidelines on the Responsible Use of AI in the Public Service* were published in May 2025 and provide us a comprehensive framework for AI adoption. The Department's approach is now rooted in this framework, balancing AI innovation with responsible governance, emphasising human oversight and public trust as central considerations in AI adoption.

In line with these Guidelines, and the Department's goal to promote and champion a culture of innovation and transformation, work is underway to update the 2023 policy to reflect the continuing advancements and developments happening within the Department and wider afield. The updated policy will provide a refreshed framework for the appropriate use of AI technologies so as to identify the right use cases for AI, and enhance the quality of our public

services, our efficiency and our productivity, and in so doing uphold ethical standards, fundamental rights, legal compliance and public trust.

Members will be familiar that the EU AI Act classifies AI systems based on risk, setting specific principles for high-risk AI applications while imposing bans on unacceptable-risk AI practices. The Department is integrating this risk-based approach, to ensure safety, respect for human rights, data privacy, and accountability, and to enhance public trust.

The Department is committed to appropriate ongoing oversight of AI deployment. We are currently reviewing the structures necessary within the Department to review high-impact AI projects, and ensure adherence to our risk-based approach.

There is no currently no deployment of AI technology within the online services that the Department provides to the public.

As a Department, the safeguarding of people's health, safety, and fundamental rights is front and centre of our service provision. Data protection and quality are key considerations in the deployment of AI, with the Department committed to protecting personal and business data in line with robust cybersecurity and ethical data handling practices.

In order to examine the technical feasibility of establishing an in-house Large Language Model service and chatbot, research has been undertaken by the Department's ICT Unit since 2024. This research operates in a sandbox environment on the Department's own business data. This data is not personal and is held on-premises under the terms of the Department's ICT Security Policy, which is itself based on National Cyber Security Centre guidelines. This research is in the low-risk category.

The sample use cases of this research are all solely in the area of knowledge management – using AI tools to improve our own personal productivity and the Department's operational efficiency. None of the use cases involve direct delivery of public services.

One use case is now implemented as part of the design and development of the Passport Service's new processing system. A digital assistant which is based on generative AI and

named ‘Ask Finn’ was introduced during 2025 for internal use by officials in the Passport Service. This digital assistant was developed internally and is based on-premises, meaning it is low-risk, extremely secure, does not leverage commercial or cloud-based systems, and does not have any capability to access or retrieve any personal information. The system will allow officers to ask questions related to the processing of passports, which ‘Finn’ will answer by pulling from the Passport Service’s policies and procedural documents. The Department intends to develop other appropriate AI use cases following a period of robust testing.

It is already clear that the current wave of technological innovation and advancement will have a profound impact on ways of working. While the opportunities offered by AI to potentially improve our public services are significant, we are highly aware that so too are the risks. The Department of Foreign Affairs and Trade intends to harness these opportunities while mitigating the risks, innovating and improving our service delivery to the benefit of citizens, while at the same time protecting our infrastructure; building public trust; and safeguarding fundamental rights.

I thank the Committee for their time and my colleagues and I welcome your questions.